

BANDEEP SINGH

"When was Aurangzeb buried? Why make it an issue after so many years? Any attempt to disturb the law and order should be dealt with strictly. India is a symbol of unity in diversity. We should not fall into the trap of any divisive forces"

AJIT PAWAR
Deputy CM, Maharashtra



"He (Aurangzeb) had come to loot, he was a thief, why glorify him? People go to take his darshan, are they his descendants? He was a parasite. Demolish it (the tomb)"

UDAYANRAJE BHONSLE, *BJP MP and descendant of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj*

"A wrong history is being put out. Aurangzeb also built many temples. I don't consider him a cruel ruler. Also, the battle between Chhatrapati Sambhaji Maharaj and Aurangzeb was for land...it was not a battle between Hindus and Muslims"

ABU AZMI, *Samajwadi Party MLA, Maharashtra*



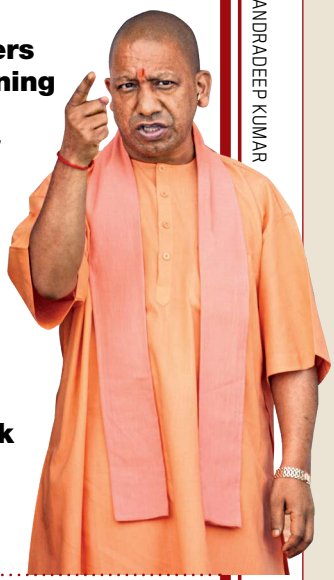
ANI





"Farmers are committing suicide. Unemployment has increased. To hide all these, the BJP comes up with new issues of Hindus and Muslims, and to entangle people in historical topics to divert their attention from the main issues"

ATUL LONDHE PATIL *National spokesperson, Congress Party*



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

"Glorifying invaders means strengthening the very roots of treason. The New India will never accept those who insult our great ancestors and praise those who attacked our civilisation, violated our women and struck at our faith"

YOGI ADITYANATH
Chief Minister, UP



"The BJP should go back and learn history. Swami Vivekananda emphasised the universal acceptance of all religions. If BJP leaders truly respected Vivekananda, they would learn from him about religious tolerance and inclusion"

AKHILESH YADAV
President, Samajwadi Party

sparked off a communal riot in Nagpur, headquarters of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), on March 17. The violence claimed the life of one person and left more than 30 people, including a few policemen, injured.

A Wave of Revanchism

Back in the 1940s, Maratha historian T.S. Shejwalkar had written presciently, "There is a terrible ghoul—a massive spectre—that is haunting Maharashtra. Its name is history." Except that it is not just Maharashtra that is witnessing social and communal conflagrations over historical perceptions. From UP to Telangana, contentious interpretations of past events, controversial historical figures and claims over places of worship are increasingly creating flashpoints on the country's socio-political landscape.

There is the ongoing legal battle over the Gyanvapi Masjid in Varanasi in UP, which revolves around claims that the 17th-century mosque, built during Aurangzeb's rule, stands on a demolished Hindu temple. The Krishna Janmabhoomi dispute in Mathura involves claims that the Shahi Idgah mosque was built at the birthplace of Lord Krishna after a temple was demolished, again during Aurangzeb's rule. In Rajasthan, Hindutva groups claim that the dargah of Sufi saint Moinuddin Chishti in Ajmer was originally a Shiva temple. In Hyderabad, communal sentiments continue to